Unit:5 Tracking Results and Measuring Success

Why Measuring Success Is Essential to the SEO Process

Introduction

- In SEO, just applying strategies is not enough. We must **measure and check results** to know if our efforts are successful. Since SEO takes time to show results, **tracking and measuring success** is very important to prove progress, improve methods, and reach business goals.
- **Example:** If you add keywords to your website today, you won't see instant results. But by measuring rankings and traffic every month, you can see whether those keywords are working.

1. Importance of Measuring Success

a) Progress Evaluation

- Measuring success shows if SEO is improving website **ranking, traffic, or sales**.
- **Example:** If your site ranking improves from page 5 to page 1 for "best shoes," it proves your SEO is working.

b) Effectiveness Check

- Helps identify which SEO strategies are successful and which need changes.
- **Example:** Blog posts may bring more visitors, while paid ads bring fewer. You can focus more on blogs.

c) Expectation Management

- Reports and measurable results build **trust with clients or management**.
- **Example:** If you show monthly reports that traffic increased by 20%, the client will be confident in your work.

d) Data-Driven Decisions

- Web analytics tools (like Google Analytics) give clear data about traffic, keywords, and user behavior. This ensures SEO strategies are made using **facts, not guesses**.
- **Example:** Instead of assuming “Instagram brings visitors,” analytics may show that most traffic comes from Google Search. So, you can focus more on Google SEO.

e) Control of Project Timeline

- By measuring results regularly, SEO professionals can check if the project is moving as planned and achieving goals within deadlines.
- **Example:** If the plan was to increase traffic by 30% in 3 months, but after 2 months the growth is only 10%, then the strategy can be changed early to meet the goal.

2. Steps in SEO Project Development (Measurement Stages)

- **Define Goals and Strategy**
  - Set clear and measurable goals like increasing traffic, generating leads, or boosting sales.
  - **Example:** Aim to increase organic traffic by 25% in 6 months

- **Review and Refine Strategy**
  - Update and adjust strategies based on progress and changing market trends.
  - **Example:** If blog posts are performing better than videos, focus more on blogs.

- **Establish Baseline**
  - Record the current performance (rankings, visitors, conversions) as a starting point.
  - **Example:** Website currently gets 5,000 monthly visitors. This acts as the baseline.

- **Implementation**
  - Start applying SEO techniques such as on-page optimization, keyword targeting, link building, and content updates.
  - **Example:** Optimize title tags and add internal links across all product pages.

- **Data Collection & Analysis**
  - Use tools like Google Analytics or SEMrush to gather data on traffic, keywords, conversions, and user behavior.
  - **Example:** Check which keywords bring the most visitors.

- **Result Verification**
  - Compare new results against the baseline and goals to see if progress is made.
  - **Example:** Traffic improved from 5,000 to 6,500 per month, meeting the 25% growth target.

- **Continuous Improvement**
  - SEO is ongoing; keep reviewing performance, finding weaknesses, and refining strategies.
  - **Example:** If bounce rate is high, improve website speed or add better content.

3. Key Metrics to Measure SEO Effectiveness

To check whether SEO strategies are working, certain **Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)** must be measured. These metrics show how well the website is performing and whether goals like traffic, sales, and branding are being achieved. **a) Major KPIs**

- **Traffic Rate**
  - Measures the number of visitors coming from search engines.
  - **Example:** If traffic increases from 2,000 to 3,500 per month after SEO, it shows growth.

- **Lead Generation**
  - Tracks how many visitors become potential customers by signing up, filling forms, or inquiring.
  - **Example:** A travel website gets 200 new booking inquiries through SEO traffic.

- **Revenue**
  - Direct sales or income generated from SEO efforts.
  - **Example:** An e-commerce store's monthly revenue grows from ₹50,000 to ₹80,000 after optimization.

- **Branding Value**
  - Measures the visibility and recognition of the brand in search results.
  - **Example:** Appearing on the first page for terms like *"best smartphones"* builds trust in the brand.

- **Acceptance (User Engagement)**
  - Tracks how users respond to the site—time spent, bounce rate, and feedback.
  - **Example:** If users spend 5 minutes on average instead of 1 minute, engagement has improved.

b) Detailed Website Metrics

- **Natural Search Traffic**
  - Visitors coming from Google, Bing, or Yahoo based on keywords.
  - **Example:** 70% of traffic comes from Google organic search.
- **Keyword Baseline**
  - Identifying keywords that generate the maximum traffic.
  - **Example:** “Buy sports shoes online” brings 40% of organic visits.
- **High-Traffic Pages**
  - Sections or pages that bring the most visitors.
  - **Example:** Blog articles bring more traffic than product pages.
- **High Conversion Pages**
  - Pages where visitors take action (buy, sign up, download).
  - **Example:** Landing page for “Free Trial” converts 15% of visitors into sign-ups.

- Search engine crawler activity (how often pages are indexed).
- Poor-performing pages (low engagement).
- Number of indexed pages in Google.
- 404 error pages and broken links.
- Best-performing pages (high visibility and engagement).

4. KPIs (Key Performance Indicators)

In SEO, KPIs are the **actionable metrics** that clearly indicate success. Examples include:

- Organic traffic growth.
- Bounce rate reduction.
- Increase in keyword rankings.
- Higher conversions (sales, sign-ups).

Discuss Measuring Search Traffic in detail.

Introduction

- Measuring search traffic is a critical part of the SEO process because it shows how users are finding a website through search engines and whether optimization efforts are working. By tracking search traffic, businesses can identify which keywords, pages, and sources are driving visitors and how these visitors behave once they arrive.

1. Factors Required for Measuring Search Traffic

- To measure search traffic effectively, the following must be analyzed:
- **Keywords** – Identify which search terms bring the most traffic.
- **Inbound Links** – Measure links from external websites that drive visitors.
- **Conversion Rate and Traffic** – Analyze how much of the traffic leads to actual conversions (sales, leads, sign-ups).

2. Analytics Tools for Measuring Search Traffic

Most hosting providers offer basic tools like AWStats or Webalizer, but advanced tools provide richer data. Common analytics solutions include:

- **Google Analytics**
- **Woopra**
- **Clicky**
- **Piwik (Matomo)**
- **Yahoo! Web Analytics**
- **WebTrends**

3. Methods of Tracking Search Traffic

(a) **Log File Tracking**

- Tracks data directly from server log files.
- Advantages:
  - Tracks search engine crawler activity.
  - Works for users without JavaScript.
  - Monitors incomplete or error page loads.
  - Data stays in-house, ensuring better security.

(b) **JavaScript Tracking**

- Uses tracking code inserted in website pages.
- Advantages:
  - Tracks outgoing links.
  - Records events like video plays or button clicks.
  - Captures screen resolution and user behavior.

4. Valuable SEO Data from Web Analytics

- **Traffic by Search Engine:** Shows which search engines (Google, Bing, Yahoo) send the most visitors.
- **Traffic by Keyword:** Identifies which search terms bring visitors and highlights successful SEO campaigns.
- **Branded vs. Non-Branded Traffic:**
  - Branded: Traffic from company/product name searches.
  - Non-Branded: More valuable, as it represents long-tail organic traffic.
- **Number of Pages Receiving Traffic:** Indicates how many pages are not just indexed but also ranking and clicked by users.
- **Referring Sites:** Shows external websites sending visitors; useful for spotting **new backlinks**.
- **Action Tracking:** Tracks user behavior such as clicks, downloads, or purchases.
- **Dashboards:** A single-page view of critical metrics tailored for different users (e.g., CEO vs. SEO analyst).

NetInsight - Our Business Web Site - Windows Internet Explorer

http://aarikant60.unicacorp.com/NetInsight8/web/index.html

File Edit View Favorites Tools Help

NetInsight - Our Business Web Site

Reports | Custom | Archive | Options

Reporting mode: Full

NetInsight

Help

unica

December 2008

Reports Overview

Dashboards

- Site Conversion Dashboard
- Trends Dashboard
- Customer Dashboard
- SEM Dashboard
- Executive
- Marketing
- Retail
- Content
- Visitor
- Traffic
- Technical
- Geographic
- What-If?

Marketing Campaigns

Paid Search Campaigns

Marketing Referrals

Marketing Integrations

Retail Analysis

Content Analysis

Our Business Web Site: 05. Site Conversion Dashboard

December 2008

Conversion funnel

Number of Visitors

603 Viewed si...nfo page

319 Viewed sign-up online form

108 Completed order form

44 Downloaded ...nformation

Next two clicks after home page

End of Visit 1,080

/ Home Page 1,998 Visitors

/ Products / Overview 189

/ Home Page 179

/ Sign up / Options 113

/ Demo / Demo options 90

Executive QuickSet

Total Unique Visitors:	4,457
Total Conversions :	1,117
Revenue:	1,965,188
Average Order Value:	2,077
ROAS %:	29,990

Geolocation of Visitors and Sales

Campaigns vs. Channel Types

1,500

1,250

Done

Internet

100%

Tying SEO to Conversion and ROI

Search Engine Optimization (SEO) is not just about increasing website visitors. The real success comes when those visitors take meaningful actions (conversions) that lead to business growth. Therefore, SEO efforts must be directly tied to Conversions and Return on Investment (ROI).

1. **Conversions**

- A conversion means the action a visitor takes that benefits the business.
  Examples of conversions:
- **Sales/Sales Revenue** → If a user searches for “sports shoes,” visits an e-commerce site, and buys shoes worth ₹2,000, this is a direct sales conversion.
- **Email/Newsletter Subscriptions** → A user signs up for fitness tips emails. Though not direct money, it helps future marketing.
- **Sign-ups** → Registering for a free trial of a software tool. Example: User signs up for Canva’s free plan.

- **Downloads** → A student downloads a free PDF from an education site.
- **Contact forms/Calls** → Filling a “Request a Callback” form on a bank’s website.
- **Visitors who Share/Link/Publicize** → A user shares your blog post on Facebook, or another blogger links to your guide. This increases reach and SEO value.
- These conversions show whether SEO is delivering real value.

2. **Cross-Channel Interaction & Attribution**

- Customers often use multiple channels before converting.
- **Example 1 (TV + SEO):** A person watches a mobile ad on TV, later searches online for reviews, and then buys.
- **Example 2 (Online + Offline):** A user compares laptop prices on Flipkart but finally buys from a local shop.
- **Example 3 (Paid + Organic):** A person clicks on a Google Ad first, leaves, but later returns via organic search to purchase.

3. Setting Up Analytics Software

Businesses use tools like Google Analytics to track what's working on their website.

👉 Example:

- Keyword "best running shoes" brings 5,000 visitors.
- Out of them, 200 buy shoes.
- **Conversion Rate** = 200 ÷ 5000 = 4%.

  This means the business should focus more on "best running shoes" keyword since it brings real customers, not just visitors.

4. Conversion Tracking Strategy

Not all actions have the same business value. So, companies assign **different values** to conversions.

👉 Examples:

- **High Value** = Direct Sale (₹5,000 shoe purchase).
- **Medium Value** = Free Trial Sign-up (may become paying customer later).
- **Low Value but useful** = Social Share (no money but spreads brand awareness).

  Example: If 100 people subscribe to a blog, and after 3 months 10 of them buy products, then subscriptions are valuable and should be tracked as an important conversion.

5. Link Bait Bump

Sometimes, viral or shareable content brings a sudden spike in traffic.

👉 Example:

- A blog post “Top 10 Free SEO Tools” goes viral on Twitter.
- 50,000 new visitors come.
- Even if only 1,000 subscribe to the newsletter, that’s a long-term win (potential future customers).

💡 Takeaway: Viral content boosts visibility, brand awareness, and future conversions.

6. Determining ROI

ROI (Return on Investment) shows if SEO is making money or wasting money.

ROI = (Profit from SEO – SEO Cost) ÷ SEO Cost × 100

👉 Example:

- SEO cost = ₹20,000
- Profit from conversions = ₹60,000
- ROI = (60,000 – 20,000) ÷ 20,000 × 100 = 200%

💡 This means for every ₹1 spent, the business got back ₹3 total (₹2 profit).

Competitive and Diagnostic Search Metrics

These metrics are like a **health check + spy tool** for SEO.

- **Competitive Metrics** → Compare with competitors.
- **Diagnostic Metrics** → Check your own website's SEO health.

They show:

✅ How many pages are indexed
✅ Which keywords are ranking
✅ How strong backlinks are
✅ Where gaps/opportunities exist

1. Competitive Search Metrics

These help you **analyze competitor strategies** and find where you can improve.

👉 Example 1: **Backlinks**

- Competitor: **1,000 backlinks**
- You: **300 backlinks**
  - 💡 **You need to improve link-building** to compete.

👉 Example 2: **Indexed Pages**

- Competitor: **5,000 pages indexed in Google**
- You: **1,500 pages indexed**
  - 💡 **Competitor covers more topics/keywords**, so you should expand your content.

👉 Example 3: **Keyword Rankings**

- Competitor: Ranks **#1 for "cheap flight tickets"**
- You: Rank on **page 2**
  💡 **Means you're missing out on high-traffic keywords → Optimize your content.**

1.Backlink Profiles

- Backlinks = **votes of trust** from other websites.
  Analyzing competitor backlinks shows **where they're getting authority** (blogs, news sites, forums).
- 👉 Example:
- Competitor has backlinks from **popular travel blogs & news sites**.
- You don't have any.
  💡 Action: Try to **get backlinks from similar trusted sources** (guest posts, partnerships, PR mentions).

2. Diagnostic Search Metrics

These metrics check the **health of your own website** and highlight problems that may reduce visibility in search engines.

a) Site Indexing Data

This shows **how many of your site's pages** are included in Google or other search engines.

👉 **Why Important?**

- Makes sure **all important pages** (like product or service pages) are indexed.
- Helps find issues like:
  - Blocked pages (robots.txt or noindex tags)
  - Duplicate content
  - Crawl errors (pages search engines can't access)

  👉 **Example:**

  Your website has 1,000 product pages, but Google only indexed **500**.

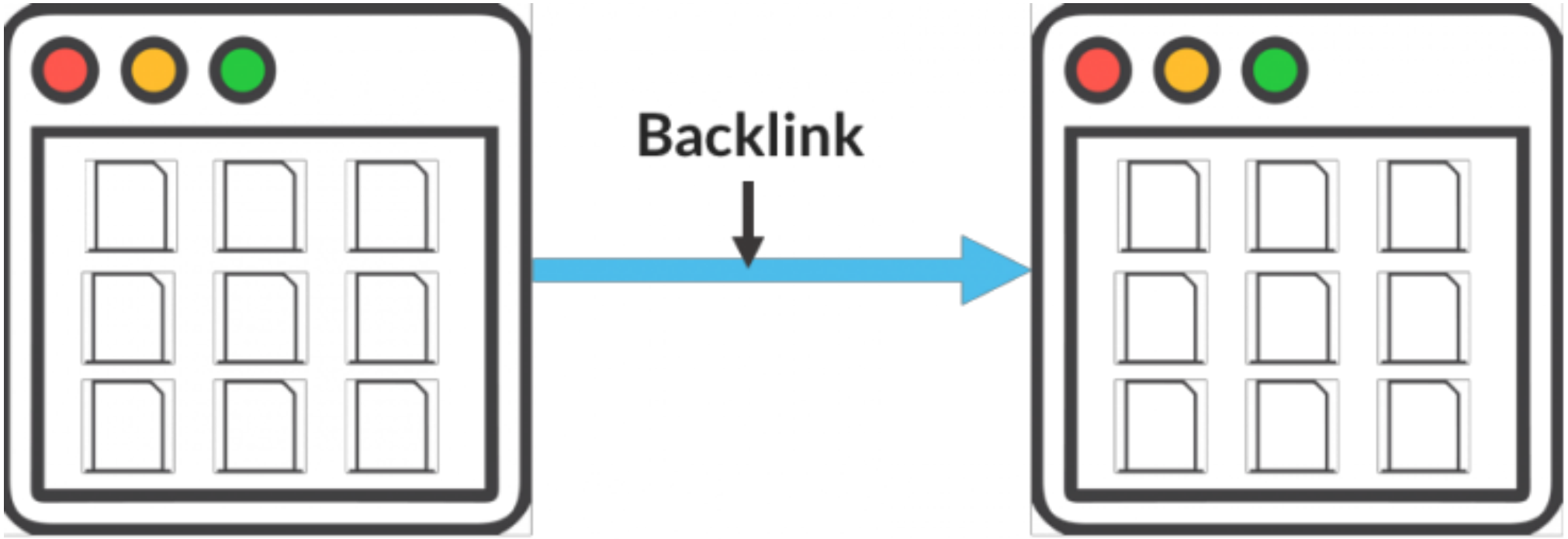
  💡 That means **half your site is invisible** → lost traffic & sales.

b) Link Building & Link Tracking

- Tracking backlinks shows if your SEO campaigns are working.
- Helps compare **link growth** vs. competitors.
- **Anchor Text Analysis** checks the words used in backlinks (important for keyword targeting).
- **Example:** If most backlinks to your site use “click here” as anchor text, but your competitor’s backlinks use “best smartphones,” they gain stronger keyword authority.

3. **Extra Knowledge**

- **Backlinks:** A backlink is when one site links to another. Example: A news site linking to your article on “AI Trends.”
- **Importance of Backlinks:** They act as a **vote of confidence**. More quality backlinks = higher domain authority = better Google ranking.



Website A

Site A has an external link to Site B

Website B

Site B has a backlink from site A

Search Engine–Supplied Tools

- These tools are provided directly by search engines to help webmasters monitor backlinks, indexing, and website performance.

1. Google Webmaster Tools (Now called Google Search Console)

- Allows website owners to **download a list of backlinks** (links pointing to their site).
- Google may **exclude insignificant links** from this report.
- **Access Restriction:** Only site owners can view links to their own site.
- **Example:**

  If your site is www.nobleuniversity.edu, you can view all pages linking to it according to Google's database.

2. Bing Webmaster Tools

- Similar to Google's tool but uses **Bing's search index**.

- Website owners can **download backlink data** in spreadsheet format.
- **Access Restriction:** Only shows backlinks to your verified website.
- **Example: You can track how many sites Bing has indexed as linking to your** SEO Department webpage.

3. Search Status (Firefox Plug-in)

- Provides **quick link data** directly from the browser.
- Ideal for **fast checks** instead of full reports.
- Shows **basic link totals** and page rank with just a few clicks.
- **Example:**
  Right-click on a page → select *"Search Status"* → instantly view backlink counts and SEO metrics.

Third-Party Link-Building Tools

- These tools are developed by private companies for **advanced backlink analysis and competitor research**.

1. Link Maps (by Bruce Clay, Inc.)

- 🔗 **Website:** www.linkmaps.com
- Maps **backlinks of any website** (including competitors).
- Uses search engine data with **advanced filtering**, such as:
  - Removes **404 error pages**.
  - Excludes **pages without links**.
  - Limits results to **4 pages per domain**.
  - Filters out **guest books** and **link farms** (spammy link networks).

2. Conductor Searchlight

- Enterprise-level **SEO and backlink management platform**.
- Provides **charts and insights** comparing your backlinks with competitors.
- **Automatically updates** as backlink data changes.

3. Stone Temple Consulting Link Focus

- Uses a **proprietary algorithm** to find the **most valuable backlinks** to a site.
- Helps focus on **quality links** rather than quantity.

4. Google Blog Search

- Though Google's link: command is limited,
  Google Blog Search shows **more comprehensive backlink data**, especially for **blog-based links** and mentions.

5. Exalead

- 🔗 **Website:** www.exalead.com/search/
- A European search engine with a **link: command** feature.
- Provides **advanced filtering** for backlink searches,offering insights beyond Google's limited data.

6. Ranking Tools (e.g., Authority Labs)

- Help monitor keyword rankings across major search engines.
- Rankings can show trends such as growth or decline in visibility.
- Useful when:
  - Achieving a top position for important keywords (brand value).
  - Detecting sudden ranking drops (e.g., from #5 to #50).
  - Observing long-term performance trends.

  - **Note:** Many automated ranking tools “scrape” Google results, which violates Google’s Webmaster Guidelines — use responsibly.

  - **Example:** Authority Labs provides daily ranking reports to track performance for keywords like “digital marketing course Noble University.”

Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) for Long-Tail SEO

Long-Tail SEO means using specific, low-competition keywords that bring traffic over time.

To check how well this works, we use some important measures (KPIs).

1. Branded-to-Non-Branded Ratio

- This shows how much of your website traffic comes from **your brand name** (branded) and how much comes from **general keywords** (non-branded).
- **High ratio** = Most visitors already know your brand → weak SEO reach→ Only known users find you.
- **Low ratio** = More visitors come from general searches → strong SEO reach→ New people find you through general searches.

  Example:
  If 70% of traffic comes from “Noble University” → branded.
  If 30% comes from “best University in Gujarat” → non-branded.

2. Unique Crawled URLs

- This means how many different pages of your website are checked (crawled) by Google or other search engines.
- More pages crawled = more chances for your website to show in search results for many keywords.

Example:

If Google visits (crawls) 500 pages of your site, your website can appear for more search terms and topics.

3. Search Visitors per Contributing Page

- This means how many of your website pages get visitors from Google or other search engines.
- More pages getting traffic = better SEO performance.

Example:
If out of 300 pages, 200 pages get visitors from Google, it means your SEO is doing well and more pages are helping bring traffic.

4. Keywords per Page

- This shows how many different keywords each page of your website ranks for in Google.
  If a page ranks for many keywords, it means the page is well-optimized and covers related topics.

Example:
One blog about “Digital Marketing Tools” might rank for 10–15 search terms like “free SEO tools,” “keyword planner alternatives,” and “best digital marketing software.”

5. Search Visitors per Keyword

- This shows how many visitors come from each keyword.
  It helps you find which keywords bring the most traffic and perform best in search results.

Example:
If the keyword “SEO course in Gujarat” brings 150 visitors every month,
it means that keyword is high-performing and valuable for your website.

6. Index-to-Crawl Ratio

- This compares how many of your website pages are shown in Google search (indexed) to how many were visited by Google (crawled).
- If the ratio is low, it means Google visited many pages but didn’t add them to search results — maybe because the content is duplicate or low quality.
- Goal: Make sure most crawled pages are also indexed to get better reach in searches.

Example: If Google crawls 500 pages but only 300 are indexed, you should improve your content quality and structure.

7. Search Visitors per Crawled Page

- This tells how much traffic each crawled page gets from search engines.
- It helps you see which search engine (Google, Bing, Yahoo) gives you more visitors.
  More visitors per crawled page = better SEO performance.

Example: If Google crawls 100 pages and those pages bring 2,000 visitors, each page brings about 20 visitors — showing strong results.

Conclusion

- Long-tail SEO takes more time to show results — unlike paid ads that can work within a few hours. Organic SEO usually takes months to grow and give steady results.
- That’s why it is important to track all the KPIs mentioned above.

- They help in:
- Checking your SEO progress and success
- Showing results and accountability to management
- Improving and adjusting SEO campaigns for better rankings and traffic

THANK
YOU